

doing the perceiving and how close to the Dreaming the fae is at the time. Both exist together rather than shifting back and forth, a shared existence that begins the moment the fae and the mortal body become one.

The Chrysalis

Changelings are as old as time, older than the stories of faeries and mortals interacting in cultures across the world. The initial changelings were born of the relationships between mortals and fae, in a time before Banality turned the world dark and cold. Modern changelings, by contrast, came about when the fae realized that they could not survive the Banality of the mortal world without some kind of protection. Most chose to engage in a ritual known as the Changeling Way, which cloaked their fae selves in mortal bodies that would allow them to hide in the Autumn world. When this first generation passed on, their fae souls were reborn into the bodies of mortal children, and changelings began to be born all over the mortal world. While some fae, like the Arcadian sidhe, choose to take mortal form in other ways, this is the primary way the fae have survived the dwindling of Glamour in the world for generations.

A child harboring a fae soul can grow for years, even into adulthood, without ever knowing the truth about her dual nature. No matter how well hidden, however, the child's true nature marks her as different. Hints might leak out, marking the child as unusual, the odd one out, or else simply the weirdo in the class. These children grow up fascinated with things most people relegate to flights of fancy, like dragons or monsters, fantasy lands, and amazing stories. They look for the unbelievable in their everyday world as the fae soul inside yearns inside to reach the Dreaming and its wonders. Still, the child will remain unaware of the fae slumbering inside her until the time to awaken occurs. This awakening, when the Dreaming within manifests in the child, is a dramatic and often traumatic experience called *Chrysalis*.

The Chrysalis is a moment of revelation when the fae self inside a mortal bursts forth in an explosion of Glamour. It's a tumultuous, overwhelming experience, as the mortal becomes not only aware of a reborn other self within her body, but of an entire world of Glamour and fantastic, wondrous, terrible things around her. She is violently inundated with sights and sensations from a world that lies just alongside, over, and beside the mortal one, where unbelievable things are real. This violent explosion is preceded by small events, tiny outpourings of Glamour, as the Dreaming tries to reach out and awaken the fae inside the mortal.

It may start small, with a mortal witnessing strange occurrences no one else sees. A teenager sees a crow sitting on his teacher's shoulder, a crow no one else notices. A child sees a stuffed T. Rex sit up in the sandbox and begin chewing on a cigar. She has visions, flashes of glorious vistas and breathtaking wonders, that she believes to be real, and even experiences vivid hallucinations in which she lives through the life experiences of a person from long ago and far away. These flashes are the fae-to-be's first look at the Dreaming, or even memories from past lives trying to remind her of who she is. These visions can

be disturbing to mortals, who may seek out psychiatric help. Many concerned parents will try and intervene to help their children, who struggle to reconcile their wonder at the things they're seeing with the reality of the mortal world. These early warnings increase in frequency and intensity and, unless impeded, end in the forceful emergence of the fae inside.

The Dream Dance

When the time is right, the warning visions stop and the Changeling enters the *dream dance*. The dance heralds the arrival of the new fae, broken from the shackles of the icy Banal world. It's a titanic explosion of power, a riot of magic and the unreal made real, as the new changeling is engulfed in the power of the Dreaming, infused with Glamour, and sees for the first time the magic that has always been around her. Nothing could have prepared her for the sensations of seeing the world without mortal blinders, as she embraces a world brighter and more intense than she could have imagined. She plunges headlong into this new experience, lost in the furious chaos of a new world unfolding around her.

The Mists that shrouded her view of the world are gone and the new changeling sees herself and her fae mien for the first time. She is bombarded with images of her past lives, of Arcadia and the Dreaming, of friends and loved ones and enemies long gone, and even glimpses of the future to come. All of it passes before her eyes so quickly that only fragments remain. The changeling in the Dream Dance battles this tide of power, overwhelmed, as Glamour pours from her and creates chimera out of her dreams, fears, hopes, and nightmares. These chimera can run rampant, attracting local fae as word spreads of flocks of baby dragons flying over Jersey City, or a haunting band of clockwork musicians wandering Golden Gate Park. Those fae nearby can recognize the flood of Glamour and the chimerical activity for what it is — a new member of their people coming into herself — and may seek to help the emerging changeling.

Those that are found are the lucky ones. A changeling is never as vulnerable as during the Dream Dance. As she spews Glamour in every direction, the changeling may attract the attention of less savory chimerical creatures that could harm the new fae. Other supernatural creatures might see the confused changeling as easy prey, and many fae are picked off before they can ever fully realize themselves fully. Still others fall to madness, unable to handle the disconcerting shift in their reality. That's why all changelings in the area of a person going through the Dream Dance have a duty to find the emerging fae and help her through the process. In exchange, they drink deep of the overflow of Glamour the new fae exudes, while they introduce their newest cousin to their lives as changelings.

Fosterage

Upon surviving the Dream Dance, the fully emerged changeling must now make her way in a wholly new magical world. Other Kithain who discovered the changeling during the Dream Dance usually bring the new fae, called a *fledgling*, to the nearest large gathering of fae or to a freehold. There, the changeling has a chance to learn about the Dreaming, fae